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SECURITY



US Army soldier pleads guilty to hacking telcos and extortion

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Former U.S. Army soldier Cameron John Wagenius pleaded guilty to hacking telecommunication companies and attempting to extort them by threatening to release stolen files, the Department of Justice [announced](#) on Tuesday.

According to the DOJ, Wagenius, who went online with the nickname “kiberphant0m,” conspired to defraud 10 victim companies by stealing their login credentials, using [brute force attacks](#) and other techniques, and then used Telegram group chats to transfer the stolen credentials and discuss hacks.

Wagenius and his conspirators also attempted to extort their victims in private and in public, including on hacking forums such as the notorious [BreachForums](#). They sold some of the stolen data and also used the stolen credentials to commit other frauds, including [SIM swapping](#) victims.

Earlier this year, Wagenius [had already pleaded guilty](#) to hacking AT&T and Verizon, a breach that led to him stealing a massive amount of call records.

Wagenius’ sentencing is scheduled for October 6, and he faces 20 years in prison, according to the press release.

The hacker has been linked to a series of hacks that originated from [the breach of cloud computing services giant Snowflake](#).

IMAGE CREDITS: [ANDREW HARRER](#) / [BLOOMBERG](#)
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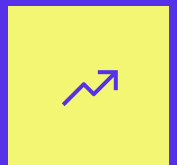
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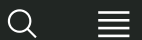
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DOJ confirms arrested US Army soldier is linked to AT&T and Verizon hacks

Zack Whittaker — 7:27 AM PST · January 18, 2025

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records. Wagenius was later extradited to Washington state.

In a new court filing on Friday, U.S. prosecutors confirmed that the charges against Wagenius are related to the earlier indictment of two alleged hackers, Connor Moucka and John Binns, who the U.S. government accused of [multiple intrusions at](#)

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[cloud computing company Snowflake](#) that saw the mass theft of data stored in its customer accounts. The Snowflake customers whose data was stolen include AT&T, which had “nearly all” of its customer call records through 2024 exfiltrated from its Snowflake account, and Verizon, from whom a substantial cache of customer call logs was taken.

U.S. Attorney Tessa Gorman [told the Seattle court](#) that “both cases arise from the same computer intrusion and extortion and include some of the same stolen victim information,” and as such, “these cases rely on overlapping evidentiary material and legal process and arguably present common questions of law and fact.”

This is the first public acknowledgment by prosecutors that Wagenius’ charges are connected to last year’s breaches at Snowflake. Security journalist Brian Krebs [first reported on the link](#) between Wagenius and the Snowflake hacks in November, and [later broke the news](#) of Wagenius’ arrest.

The account hacks at Snowflake became one of the most wide-reaching cyberattacks of last year, affecting [AT&T](#), [LendingTree](#), [Santander Bank](#), [Ticketmaster](#), and at least 160 other companies. The hackers allegedly stole huge banks of personally identifiable and sensitive corporate data that companies stored in Snowflake, in part by [using passwords stolen from employee computers with malware](#). Most of the affected Snowflake customers were not using multi-factor protection, which Snowflake did not require of its customers at the time.

According to Krebs’ reporting, following the [earlier arrest of Moucka by Canadian authorities](#), Wagenius claimed in a post on a known cybercrime forum to have access to the call logs of Vice President Kamala Harris and President-elect

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Donald Trump, and threatened to leak all of the stolen files unless Moucka was released.

Prosecutors accuse the Snowflake hackers of stealing data that includes personal information, cell phone and IMEI numbers, dates of birth, postal and email addresses, passwords, Social Security numbers, government-issued identity numbers, and payment card and bank account numbers.

Wagenius was ordered on January 8 to be detained and is understood to be in custody in Washington state.

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Zack Whittaker

Security Editor |

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Snowflake hackers identified and charged with stealing 50 billion AT&T records

Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai

— 9:17 AM PST · November 12, 2024

The U.S. government has accused Connor Moucka and John Binns of being the hackers who broke into the systems of AT&T, stealing around 50 billion customer call and text records.

IMAGE CREDITS:

PAU BARRENA / AFP / GETTY IMAGES

In July, [AT&T said hackers stole the phone records of “nearly all” of its cellular and landline customers](#), as well as calls and text message records — such as who contacted whom by phone or text — but not the content of the messages. At the time, AT&T said it would notify around 110 million AT&T customers of the breach and that the records were stolen from its systems hosted on Snowflake, a provider of cloud services for data analysis.

Until the Department of Justice’s indictment against the two hackers, which was filed on Sunday, the total number of stolen AT&T customer records was unknown.

The document does not mention AT&T. Instead, it mentions “Victim-2,” describing it as “a major

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telecommunications company located in the United States,” which was breached around April 14. When AT&T previously confirmed it was breached, it said the company learned of the hack on April 19. This means that both the description of what kind of company Victim-2 is, and the dates of its breach, align with what AT&T had publicly disclosed, making it almost certain that Victim-2 is indeed AT&T.

AT&T did not respond to a request for comment.

DOJ spokesperson Emily Langlie declined to comment.

Contact Us

Do you have more information about the AT&T breach? Or other Snowflake-related breaches? From a non-work device, you can contact Lorenzo Franceschi-Bicchierai securely on Signal at +1 917 257 1382, or via Telegram and Keybase @lorenzofb, or [email](#). You also can contact TechCrunch via [SecureDrop](#).

Overall, [according to the indictment](#), Moucka and Binns accessed “billions of sensitive customer records” and were successful in extorting at least three victims of at least 36 bitcoin (around \$2.5 million when the victims paid) over the span of almost a year, from around November 2023 to October 10 of this year.

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Prosecutors say Moucka, who lived in Canada, is also known online as “judische,” “catist,” “waif,” and “cllyels,” and Binns, who lived in Turkey, was known as “irdev” and “j_irdev1337.” [Moucka was arrested in Canada last week](#). Binns was previously arrested in Turkey, [according to 404 Media](#).

In August, Binns [took credit for the AT&T breach](#) with The Wall Street Journal. Moucka, through his moniker “Judische,” [told 404 Media](#) that he thought he'd be arrested soon.

AT&T is just one of several victims who had sensitive data stolen from their Snowflake instances. Over the last months, hackers also broke into [Santander Bank](#), [Ticketmaster](#), and [around 165 other corporate customers](#). All these companies use Snowflake.

Prosecutors alleged that by breaking into the victim companies' Snowflake instances, the hackers stole troves of sensitive personal and corporate data, including social security numbers, driver's license numbers, passport numbers, and banking information, which makes these Snowflake-related breaches some of [the worst cyberattacks of the year](#). In some cases, the hackers also asked victims for a ransom by threatening them with

leaking the stolen information, threats that they followed up on at times.

[Wired previously reported](#) that AT&T paid a hacker \$370,000 in an attempt to get them to delete the stolen records. Prosecutors said in the indictment that Victim-2 paid a ransom to the hackers.

This story has been updated to include DOJ's no comment.

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